

WORKPLACE ETHICS, COMMUNICATION & DECISION-MAKING

Frameworks • Theories • Step-by-Step Application • Multiple Examples • Case Studies

This expanded handbook is designed to explain not just WHAT each framework is, but HOW it works, WHEN to use it, its strengths and limitations, and how to apply it to realistic workplace situations.

HOW TO STUDY THIS GUIDE

For every framework, learn five things: **(1) core idea, (2) decision question, (3) procedure, (4) strengths and limitations, and (5) examples.** Then practice comparing how different frameworks can reach different conclusions about the same workplace problem.

PART I — WORKPLACE ETHICS: THEORIES AND FRAMEWORKS

1. Consequentialism / Utilitarian Thinking

Core idea: Evaluate alternatives primarily by their expected consequences. In workplace use, ask which option produces the greatest overall benefit and least overall harm for affected stakeholders.

Decision question: What are the likely short-term and long-term consequences of each option?

Procedure:

- List realistic options.
- Identify all stakeholders.
- Estimate benefits and harms for each group.
- Consider probability and severity of outcomes.
- Compare short-term and long-term consequences.
- Choose the option with the strongest overall ethical outcome.

Example 1: A company must choose between shutting a product temporarily for safety testing or continuing sales. Consequential reasoning includes customer harm, employee impact, financial loss, and long-term trust.

Example 2: A manager chooses between two project schedules. One creates severe burnout for a small team; the other delays delivery slightly but reduces harm.

Strength: Useful for policy, risk, and stakeholder-impact decisions. **Limitation:** Important rights can be threatened if decision-makers focus only on aggregate benefit.

2. Deontology / Duty-Based Ethics

Core idea: Some professional duties and moral constraints should not be ignored merely because breaking them could produce a convenient result.

Decision question: What duties, commitments, rules, and professional obligations apply?

Procedure:

- Identify the relevant duty.
- Ask whether the action involves deception, exploitation, coercion, or misuse of persons.
- Check professional obligations and commitments.
- Consider whether the underlying rule could be applied consistently.
- Respect persons rather than treating them merely as tools.

Example 1: Changing financial numbers to protect a department may improve short-term results but violates duties of honesty and accurate reporting.

Example 2: Sharing a customer's confidential information to impress a colleague violates confidentiality even if no immediate harm occurs.

Strength: Provides strong boundaries. **Limitation:** Duties can conflict, requiring judgment about priority.

3. Rights-Based Framework

Core idea: Ethical decisions must respect important rights such as privacy, informed choice, dignity, fair treatment, and freedom from unjust discrimination.

Decision question: Whose rights are affected, and are any being unjustifiably restricted?

Examples:

- Employee monitoring software may improve productivity but can threaten privacy and autonomy.
- An employee has a right to fair treatment during a disciplinary process.
- Customers have legitimate interests in truthful information and appropriate handling of personal data.

Strength: Protects individuals from being sacrificed for convenience. **Limitation:** Rights may conflict with one another.

4. Justice and Fairness Framework

Core idea: Examine whether people are treated fairly and whether benefits, burdens, opportunities, and procedures are distributed justly.

- **Distributive fairness:** Are rewards and burdens allocated fairly?
- **Procedural fairness:** Is the decision-making process fair and consistent?
- **Corrective fairness:** How should harm or wrongdoing be repaired?

Example 1: Promotions should use relevant criteria rather than personal friendships.

Example 2: A disciplinary policy should not punish similar behavior differently without a justified reason.

Strength: Excellent for HR, promotion, pay, and discrimination issues. **Limitation:** People may disagree about what counts as a fair distribution.

5. Virtue Ethics

Core idea: Ethics is also about professional character. Ask what honesty, courage, fairness, responsibility, humility, and practical wisdom require.

Decision question: What would a professionally responsible and virtuous person do?

Example 1: A junior employee respectfully raises a safety concern despite fear of criticism; courage and integrity are central.

Example 2: A manager admits a mistake instead of blaming the team; accountability and humility are demonstrated.

Strength: Builds long-term professional character. **Limitation:** It may provide less mechanical guidance for highly complex policy decisions.

6. Care Ethics

Core idea: Pay attention to relationships, vulnerability, context, empathy, and responsibilities toward people who depend on organizational decisions.

Example 1: During restructuring, leaders should consider not only financial efficiency but also the impact on vulnerable employees.

Example 2: A manager handles an employee's personal crisis with appropriate empathy while maintaining professional boundaries.

Strength: Prevents overly impersonal decision-making. **Limitation:** Care for close relationships must not become favoritism.

7. Stakeholder Framework

Core idea: Identify everyone materially affected and analyze their interests, influence, benefits, and risks.

Procedure:

- List stakeholders.
- Identify their legitimate interests.
- Estimate positive and negative effects.
- Identify vulnerable or less powerful groups.
- Look for options that reduce avoidable harm.
- Explain trade-offs transparently.

Example: Before outsourcing work, consider employees, customers, shareholders, suppliers, communities, and long-term organizational capability.

8. Common-Good Framework

Core idea: Evaluate whether a decision supports shared conditions needed for people and institutions to function well, such as trust, safety, public resources, and cooperation.

Example: Hiding a cybersecurity breach may protect a company temporarily but undermine public trust and collective security.

9. Restorative Framework

Core idea: After wrongdoing, focus on acknowledging harm, accountability, repair, restitution, and rebuilding trust.

Example: After a data breach, an organization should investigate, notify appropriately, repair systems, support affected people, and prevent recurrence—not merely punish an individual.

PART II — COMMUNICATION THEORIES AND FRAMEWORKS

10. Transactional Communication Model

Core idea: Communication is not simply one person sending information to another; participants continuously interpret, respond, and influence one another.

Example: In a meeting, silence may be interpreted as agreement even when it actually reflects confusion. Good communicators actively check understanding.

11. The 7 Cs Framework

C	Meaning	Workplace example
Clear	Easy to understand	State the action requested explicitly.
Concise	No unnecessary material	Use short paragraphs and focused messages.
Concrete	Specific and supported	Give dates, numbers, and observable facts.
Correct	Accurate and appropriate	Check facts and terminology.
Coherent	Logically organized	Present context before request.
Complete	Contains needed information	Include deadline and next step.
Courteous	Respectful tone	Disagree without attacking the person.

12. Active Listening Framework

- Attend fully.
- Do not interrupt prematurely.
- Ask open and clarifying questions.
- Paraphrase key points.

- Check assumptions.
- Respond to the issue, not an imagined intention.

Example: Instead of replying immediately, say: 'So your main concern is that the deadline is unrealistic because the required data have not arrived—is that correct?'

13. SBI Feedback Framework

Situation → Behavior → Impact.

Example: 'In yesterday's client meeting (Situation), you interrupted the client three times while they were explaining the problem (Behavior). This made it harder to understand their concern and created tension (Impact).'

Why useful: It focuses on observable behavior rather than labeling someone as 'rude' or 'bad.'

14. DESC Framework for Assertive Communication

- **D — Describe:** state observable facts.
- **E — Express:** explain the impact or concern.
- **S — Specify:** state what you need.
- **C — Consequences:** explain the positive result of change.

Example: 'The last three reports were submitted after the agreed deadline. This delays the team's review. Please send the next report by 4 PM Friday. This will allow the team to complete the client submission on time.'

15. Difficult Conversation Framework

Observation → Impact → Perspective → Listening → Request → Agreement.

Example: A manager addresses repeated lateness by discussing observable attendance patterns, listening for underlying causes, agreeing on expectations, and documenting the plan.

16. Nonviolent Communication (NVC) Structure

Observation → Feeling → Need → Request.

Workplace example: 'When project changes are announced after work has already started, I become concerned because the team needs predictable requirements. Could we agree to communicate approved changes through one documented channel?'

PART III — DECISION-MAKING THEORIES AND FRAMEWORKS

17. Rational Decision-Making Model

- Define the problem.
- Set objectives and constraints.
- Gather relevant evidence.
- Generate alternatives.
- Define criteria.
- Evaluate alternatives.
- Assess risk.
- Choose and implement.
- Review outcomes.

Example: Selecting software should not begin with 'Which product do we like?' Start by defining requirements, security needs, cost limits, integration requirements, alternatives, and evaluation criteria.

18. Weighted Decision Matrix

Use when: several alternatives must be compared against multiple criteria.

Steps:

- Choose criteria.
- Assign each criterion a weight.
- Score each option.
- Multiply score × weight.
- Calculate totals.
- Review whether important qualitative factors are missing.

Example: Hiring vendors using weighted criteria: cost 25%, quality 30%, security 25%, support 20%. A vendor with the lowest price may still lose if quality or security scores are weak.

19. Cost–Benefit Analysis

Compare expected costs and benefits, including indirect and long-term effects where possible.

Example: Automation may reduce labor cost but require training, maintenance, cybersecurity investment, and change-management costs.

20. SWOT Analysis

Strengths and Weaknesses are internal factors; **Opportunities and Threats** are external factors.

Example: Before launching a new service, identify internal capabilities and gaps alongside market opportunities and competitive risks.

Limitation: SWOT organizes thinking but does not automatically rank alternatives.

21. OODA Loop

Observe → Orient → Decide → Act. Useful when conditions change quickly and decisions require continuous adaptation.

Example: During a service outage, teams observe system behavior, orient using operational context, decide on a mitigation, act, and repeat.

22. PDCA Cycle

Plan → Do → Check → Act. Useful for continuous improvement.

Example: Improve customer response time by planning a change, testing it, measuring results, then standardizing or revising the approach.

23. Risk Matrix

Evaluate risks using at least **likelihood × impact**. High-impact, high-likelihood risks generally deserve priority.

Example: A rare inconvenience may be lower priority than a moderately likely cybersecurity incident with severe consequences.

24. Six Thinking Hats

- White: facts and information.
- Red: feelings and intuition.
- Black: risks and cautions.
- Yellow: benefits and value.
- Green: creativity and alternatives.
- Blue: process control and synthesis.

Example: Before a major restructuring, a team deliberately examines data, emotional impacts, risks, benefits, creative alternatives, and the decision process.

25. Decision Biases

- Confirmation bias — searching for supporting evidence only.
- Anchoring — relying too heavily on the first number or idea.
- Sunk-cost fallacy — continuing because of past investment.
- Availability bias — overestimating memorable events.
- Overconfidence — underestimating uncertainty.
- Groupthink — suppressing dissent to preserve agreement.

Countermeasure: assign someone to challenge assumptions, search for disconfirming evidence, define criteria before choosing, and conduct a post-decision review.

PART IV — DETAILED INTEGRATED CASE STUDIES

CASE STUDY 1 — Pressure to Alter a Report

Scenario: A project manager tells an analyst to remove unfavorable results from a report before sending it to senior leadership. The manager argues that the negative results are temporary and could damage the team's reputation.

Framework analysis:

- **Ethics:** Consequentialism considers reputation versus harm from misleading decisions; duty ethics emphasizes honesty; rights-based analysis considers leaders' right to accurate information; virtue ethics emphasizes integrity and courage.
- **Communication:** Clarify the request, explain concerns using facts, avoid personal accusations, and propose accurate contextual reporting.
- **Decision-making:** Preserve the original data, identify alternatives, consult reporting policies, document relevant communication, and escalate appropriately if necessary.

Recommended approach: Recommended reasoning: do not falsify or conceal material information. Present accurate results with context and improvement plans.

CASE STUDY 2 — Promotion Decision

Scenario: A manager must select one of two employees. One is a close personal friend with adequate performance. The other has stronger documented performance but less personal connection.

Framework analysis:

- **Justice:** use relevant and consistent criteria.
- **Stakeholder framework:** consider candidates, team morale, organizational trust, and customers.
- **Conflict of interest:** disclose the personal relationship and seek independent review where appropriate.
- **Communication:** communicate criteria and decisions professionally without disclosing unnecessary private details.

Recommended approach: Recommended reasoning: use documented criteria and protect procedural fairness.

CASE STUDY 3 — Team Conflict and Communication Failure

Scenario: Two engineers disagree about a technical approach. Meetings become hostile, and other team members stop contributing.

Framework analysis:

- **Communication:** use active listening and separate people from proposals.
- **Decision-making:** define evaluation criteria such as security, cost, reliability, and timeline; use a weighted comparison if useful.
- **Ethics:** respect requires that disagreement not become humiliation or exclusion.

Recommended approach: Recommended reasoning: facilitate a structured discussion and evaluate proposals against agreed criteria.

CASE STUDY 4 — Customer Data Request

Scenario: A marketing team requests access to detailed customer data originally collected for service delivery. The marketing use could increase revenue.

Framework analysis:

- **Rights:** examine privacy and legitimate expectations.
- **Consequences:** include revenue, customer harm, loss of trust, and long-term reputational effects.
- **Duty:** review confidentiality commitments and applicable organizational obligations.
- **Decision-making:** consider less intrusive alternatives such as aggregated or anonymized data where appropriate.

Recommended approach: Recommended reasoning: purpose limitation, data minimization, and proper authorization should guide the decision.

CASE STUDY 5 — Deadline Versus Safety

Scenario: A product is scheduled for launch, but late testing reveals a possible safety issue. Delaying the launch will cause major financial loss.

Framework analysis:

- **Utilitarian:** compare financial loss with potential customer harm and long-term trust.
- **Duty:** avoid knowingly exposing people to unjustified risk.
- **Stakeholder:** customers may bear risks while the company receives benefits.
- **Decision-making:** assess severity and probability, investigate rapidly, and establish clear launch criteria.

Recommended approach: Recommended reasoning: financial pressure should not replace a credible safety assessment.

PART V — QUICK FRAMEWORK SELECTION GUIDE

If your main question is...	Start with...
What creates the best overall outcome?	Consequentialism / Cost-benefit
What duties or boundaries apply?	Duty-based ethics
Whose rights may be violated?	Rights framework
Is the process fair?	Justice / procedural fairness
Who is vulnerable or dependent?	Care ethics
Who is affected?	Stakeholder analysis
What would demonstrate good professional character?	Virtue ethics
How do we communicate feedback clearly?	SBI / DESC
How do we compare multiple options?	Weighted decision matrix
How do we improve a recurring process?	PDCA
How do we act under rapidly changing conditions?	OODA
How do we identify and prioritize uncertainty?	Risk matrix

FINAL MASTER PROCESS

1. DEFINE → 2. GET FACTS → 3. IDENTIFY STAKEHOLDERS → 4. IDENTIFY ETHICAL ISSUES → 5. COMMUNICATE AND LISTEN → 6. GENERATE OPTIONS → 7. APPLY RELEVANT FRAMEWORKS → 8. ASSESS RISKS → 9. DECIDE → 10. ACT → 11. REVIEW AND LEARN.